the same way you people fought against Batista's."[7] Brent later learned that, in the context of internal divisions in the Black Panther Party, Eldridge Cleaver had told Cuban authorities that Brent was a U.S. spy, which accounted for his lengthy incarceration upon arrival in Cuba. Nevertheless, it was also clear that his Cuban interrogators were not impressed with his revolutionary pronouncements. Once released from jail, he was sent to what he called a halfway house with other political exiles from the United States. While the conditions were privileged, in material terms, they were also isolated from the rest of Cuban society. "The government preferred not to include us in a regular work plan," he realized later. "We were foreigners and our ideas about revolution were vague, naive, and romantic."[8]

The account he heard of Eldridge Cleaver's time in Cuba was also illuminating. "Eldridge Cleaver had come to Cuba from Canada by boat. The Cubans took him in, gave him a house and a car, and let him shop in special stores. He had access to the best restaurants, bars, and nightclubs in Havana. His house was always filled with young Cubans who admired him as a high official of the Black Panther Party. He got away with a lot of things here for a while, but when he started organizing a Panther chapter in Havana, the shit hit the fan."[9]

Mark Sawyer surveys the various black nationalists from the United States who spent time in Cuba and their wide variety of reactions to the Revolution and its approach to racial issues. "Cuba played a central role in defining revolutionary and cultural nationalism in opposition to each other in the 1960s and 1970s," he concludes.[10]

Merely declaring an end to racial discrimination does not in itself bring about a transformation of deeply imbedded structural inequalities, as the experience of the United States has shown. Decades after school segregation and other forms of racial discrimination were outlawed in the United States, both de facto segregation and other forms of inequality continue to flourish. In 2007, 40 percent of African American children attended schools that are 90–100 percent black.[11] But Cuba's legislation of racial equality took place in the context of a massive socioeconomic transformation. How successful was it?